Although the Nazis saw a reduction of votes in 1932, as is known, Hitler was assisted to power by a group of conservative politicians led by Franz von Papen, who – convinced he could tame and manipulate Hitler – persuaded President Paul von Hindenburg to nominate the Nazi as Chancellor on 30 January 1933.

From here on, one man's magnetism proved to be Germany's fatal attraction. Once in the saddle, the National Socialists squashed opposition, as they raced to transform Germany into a police state. The communist headquarters at Liebknecht House in Berlin was raided on 4 February and all demonstrations organised by the KPD were forbidden in Prussia, Thuringia, Brunswick and Mecklenburg. By 2 March, the Swastika was hoisted over Liebknecht House, communist propaganda was confiscated as were socialist, and other democratic newspapers. Nazi action against political opposition was not only swift but thorough, right down to the village level. As KPD deputies and officials were traumatised or detained, Thälmann ordered measures to protect the party and to continue its fight underground. Soon after, though, Thälmann was seized and dispatched to prison. According to Honecker's memoirs, of the 360,000 members which the KPD counted in December 1932, at least 18,000 were arrested and detained during the first six weeks of the Hitler regime.

To make matters worse, one more twist of fate in favour of the Nazis occurred on 27 February when an arson attack by a Dutch communist destroyed the Reichstag. From that moment, the whole machinery of Nazi disinformation blamed the fire on communist agitators. The KPD was formally banned on 14 July, when the Nazis were declared the only legally permitted party in Germany.

From this point on, Erich Honecker – the young propagandist – lived a precarious existence. When away from the autonomous Saarland – separated from Hitler's grip by the Treaty of Versailles, he worked underground, existing in a world of impoverished resisters, code names and secret gatherings. During the spring and early summer of 1933, he crossed over several times into the Third Reich to attend illegal meetings at Mannheim, Mainz and Frankfurt-am-Main. 'We compared notes on the anti-fascist struggle and discussed measures to support the illegal work of